

Episode 148: Long Ago... 87 1995 Part 7 *Dragon Ball Z's* End in June

Have you all seen it yet? The movie "SPACE BATTLESHIP Yamato." I couldn't stand it anymore and eagerly went to see it on the second day of release.

As for my impression, I was quite satisfied... If I write that, everyone will probably tell me I'm "too soft!" again (laugh).

Honestly, it's impossible to remake that TV series' massive 26-episode story exactly as-is in a slightly over 2-hour movie. Live-action adaptation is, I think, an act of extracting essence, cutting away various things, and "generalising." In that regard, I honestly thought they worked quite hard. The bold setting changes, the "repositioning" of Kodai Susumu and Mori Yuki's characters including their personalities - that was skilful. Other characters too, especially Sanada-san and Saito, were magnificent.

However, what I regret is that I wanted to see more of Yamato itself - more footage of Yamato as a space battleship. Not just Yamato's gallant heroic figure, but I wanted to see much more footage of Yamato getting damaged yet still trying to advance forward while enduring attacks. Since I'm on the periphery of commercial video production, I can imagine various production circumstances, but we old fans already love the ship called Yamato itself, so that treatment was disappointing.

Well, it's a work where old fans like me who watched religiously from the first episode's original broadcast in October 1974 are everywhere, so it must be difficult in many ways (laugh). And we, for better or worse, watch while supplementing various omitted details, so how did it look to young people experiencing "Yamato" for the first time with this movie? I think about such things. And I want those young people to definitely watch the original *Space Battleship Yamato* TV series - all 26 episodes!

Anyway.

The end of "Dragon Ball's" serialisation in Weekly Shonen Jump was finally decided. Somehow, the feeling of "ah, finally..." was big within me too. Toriyama Akira-san's manga - "Dr. Slump" and then "Dragon Ball" - had always been there for over ten years. And they became anime including TV, and I'll never forget - the first professional cel I ever painted as a part-timer was *Dr. Slump* TV, and while *Dragon Ball* had little TV involvement, regarding theatrical versions, especially after becoming *Z*, I'd been working with considerable attachment up to this point.

A bit of a digression, but TV series *Dragon Ball Z* inevitably caught up with Jump's serialisation, so waiting for magazine release before starting scenario composition was too late. But future stories existed only in Toriyama-san's head. So manuscript pages with name (panel layouts and dialogue in rough form) were sent from the editorial department to Toei Animation as they were completed. We could secretly read ahead. Well, there were no pictures, so just story development.

"Since the original serialisation is ending, TV and theatrical versions will end before long too" - such feelings were there in an unexpectedly large way. And the theatrical *Dragon Ball Z* we were making now would probably be the last theatrical version.

Now, that theatrical *Dragon Ball Z: Dragon Fist Explosion!! If Goku Won't Do It, Who Will?* - as usual, we started by confirming roughly where in the original this episode was supposed to occur. This determines "who's currently dead, who hasn't appeared yet" or "who's revived and what techniques they can use" - we have to balance with the original and TV series progress. As always, we're careful not to do anything strange.

Particularly around this time, the fusion technique "Fusion" that appeared in the previous work was popular, and Goten and Trunks desperately wanted to fuse (bitter laugh). "Don't tell me new fusion techniques will appear this time too? (sweat)" I thought, but that didn't happen. Ah, good (laugh). Actually, I hate that "Fusion." They don't need to combine - if each could individually increase their power, that would be fine! ...Or rather, wasn't that competition the original form of *Dragon Ball*? I'd been thinking that all along.

This time's point was that it was all night scenes. Actually, by setting, the Hirudegarn sealed within hero Tapion would break the seal and appear when Tapion fell asleep. So battle scenes were almost all "night" backgrounds. Throughout the entire film, night scenes were abnormally long.

And it was endless urban warfare. Actually, theatrical *Dragon Ball Z* had tried to avoid urban warfare until then. Because fighting in the city means destroying various buildings, and rubble from collapsing buildings and people in the city make animation extremely difficult. And no matter how difficult, that difficulty doesn't really relate to the story's core. Until then, they'd say "if we fight here, everyone will be in danger!" and move to fight in places far from human habitation, but this time they fought right in the city.

Why the scenario became like that is unclear. Was it trying to change the story by making such developments? Certainly the visuals looked different from previous theatrical *Dragon Ball Z*, but hmm, how was it? For me, I had the feeling "I don't like making realistic rubble and collapse footage" from the previous theatrical *Dragon Ball Z: Fusion Reborn!! Goku and Vegeta*, so... even if not that realistic, I was resistant to waging battles explosively in the city. So honestly, I wasn't in a very good mood.

And that subtly reflected in the colours too (bitter laugh). Smoke colours in urban warfare became the most subtle colours in my history, competing for 1st or 2nd place. Honestly, they weren't beautiful. Certainly there were many night battle scenes, naturally with night city backgrounds. I was specifying colours balancing with background art, but used only gradually darker & lower saturation colours. Even though it was dark, couldn't I have used colours that looked more beautiful? Actually, I was full of regret watching the screen afterward. With today's digital colouring, you can quickly convert finished paintings to different colours, but back then, fixing finished work meant repainting from scratch. Moreover, massive colour-matching cuts were specified all at once and came back painted all at once - no time leeway. Needless to say, I approached completion inspection and rushes check with truly dark feelings.

And the climax was the yellow dragon's descent! Hmm, truly, story material was exhausted - I keenly felt that. The TV and theatrical series that had continued endlessly - their former charm had become quite questionable.

And in such circumstances, that day finally came. The end of *Dragon Ball's* serialisation in Weekly Shonen Jump magazine was decided.

(10.12.14)